

Madison Dell

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Research Areas

Quantitative education policy; economics of education; experimental and quasi-experimental methods; postsecondary access, persistence, and success; vocational education and training.

Employment

Postdoctoral Researcher, University of Zurich 2025–
Swiss Leading House: Economics of Education, Firm Behavior, and Training Policies

Sr. Director for Strategic Research Initiatives, Tennessee Board of Regents 2022–25

Research Analyst, Tennessee Higher Education Commission 2016–19

Education

Ph.D. **Economics of Education**, Stanford University 2023
Dissertation: “Unlocking opportunity, advancing equity: Improving college outcomes for marginalized students” (available [here](#))
Committee: Eric Bettinger (Chair), Thomas S. Dee, Anthony Lising Antonio, Alvin Pearman

M.A. **Economics**, Stanford University 2022

M.A. **Higher Education Administration**, Louisiana State University 2015

B.I.S. **Integrated Studies**, University of Tennessee at Chattanooga 2014

Publications

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

Domingue, B. W., **Dell, M.**, Lang, D., Silverman, R., Yeatman, J., & Hough, H. (2022). The effect of COVID on oral reading fluency during the 2020–2021 academic year. *AERA Open*, 8. <https://doi.org/10.1177/23328584221120254>.

Collier, D. A., Fitzpatrick, D., **Dell, M.**, Snideman, S. S., Marsicano, C. R., Kelchen, R., & Wells, K. E. (2022). We want you back: Uncovering the influences on in-person instructional operations in fall 2020. *Research in Higher Education*, 63(5), 741–767. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11162-021-09665-5>.

Lee, J. L., **Dell, M.**, González Canché, M. S., Monday, A., & Klafehn, A. (2021). The hidden costs of corroboration: Estimating the effects of financial aid verification on college enrollment. *Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis*, 43(2), 233–252. <https://doi.org/10.3102/0162373721989304>.

Book Chapter

House, E. A. & **Dell, M.** (2020). Keeping the promise: Early outcomes of Tennessee’s tuition-free college initiative. In L. W. Perna & E. J. Smith (Eds.), *Improving Research-Based Knowledge of College Promise Programs* (pp. 151–172). AERA. <https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctvxw3phv.10>.

Research and Policy Reports

Feygin, A., Miller, T., Bettinger, E., & **Dell, M.** (2022). *Advising for college success: A systematic review of the evidence*. College Completion Network.
<https://eric.ed.gov/?id=ED626933>.

Dell, M. (2021). *State authorization research: Findings, themes, and future directions*. State Higher Education Executive Officers Association. Report available [here](#).

Dell, M., Lee, J., & Weeden, D. (2021). *Investigating factors associated with college openings and closures: The role of state authorization policies*. State Higher Education Executive Officers Association. Paper available [here](#).

Working Papers

Matheny, K. T., **Dell, M.**, Gluek, G., Baker, R., Bettinger, E., Monday, A., & Mesa, H. (2025). Fast track to success? A mixed methods evaluation of condensed course formats at Tennessee community colleges. <https://edworkingpapers.com/ai26-1346>. *Revise and resubmit, Journal of Policy Analysis and Management*.

Dell, M., Lehnert, P., Backes-Gellner, U., & Bettinger, E. (2024). The effect of postsecondary educational institutions on local economies: A bird's-eye view. <https://www.nber.org/papers/w32679>. *Under review*.

Dell, M., Brox, E., Palffy, P., Schilter, C., & Backes-Gellner, U. (2026). Choice architecture in occupational choices. <https://ideas.repec.org/p/iso/educat/0255.html>.

Dell, M. & Monday, A. (2026). Unequal and persistent effects of student loan policy: Evidence from Parent PLUS reforms <https://edworkingpapers.com/ai26-1483>.

Grants, Fellowships, and Honors

Grant

Fast track to success? A mixed methods evaluation of condensed course formats 2022–24
Funder: Ascendium Education Group, Co-PI, \$734,300

Fellowships

[Stanford Graduate Fellowship in Science and Engineering \(VPGE\)](#) 2021–24
~50,000/year for 3 years (*Forfeited after securing full-time employment in 2022.*)

[Doctoral Training Program, Quantitative Education Policy Analysis \(IES\)](#) 2019–21
~30,000/year for 2 years

Honors

[AEI Education Policy Academy](#) 2022
[SHEEO & Gates Community of Practice: Data Modeling for State Attainment Goals](#) 2018
[NCES Data Institute](#) 2018

Teaching Experience

Adjunct Assistant Professor, Vanderbilt University (HOD 2500: Systematic Inquiry), Spring 2025. Instructor of record; 87 undergraduate students; managed 3 teaching assistants; transitioned the course from in-person to hybrid modality.

Teaching Assistant, Stanford University (PUBLPOL 301B: Economic Policy Analysis for Policymakers), Spring 2020–2022. 15–20 undergraduate and graduate students; taught weekly discussion sections to provide additional support for students; redesigned the course for online delivery during COVID (2020–2021); resumed in-person instruction in 2022.

Invited Talks

* indicates the presenting author(s)

Dell, M.*, Palffy, P., Brox, E., Schilter, C., & Backes-Gellner, U. (2026, May 11). *Choice architecture and occupational choices*. Lecture delivered in the [Seminar of Economics and Management \(SEAM\)](#) at Paderborn University.

Dell, M.* (2025, February 27). *The Tennessee Coaching Project*. Guest lecture delivered in Dr. Cara DeLoach's Research in Human Development (HDS 7810) class at Vanderbilt University.

DeLoach, C.* & **Dell, M.*** (2025, January 21). *Pathways to transfer & community college student success*. Guest lecture delivered in Dr. Emily House's Community Colleges, Credentialing, and Vocationalism in Higher Education (HEA 6220) class at Vanderbilt University.

Dell, M.* (2024, October 14). *An introduction to the Tennessee Coaching Project*. Guest lecture delivered in Dr. Christine Dickason's Qualitative Research Methods (EDUC 8122) class at George Washington University.

Dell, M.* (2024, February 23). *Strategic research initiatives at TBR: Accelerated courses and the Coaching Project*. Guest lecture delivered in Dr. Rich Rhoda and Dr. Jill Channing's Spring 2024 Weekend Seminar I for the Certificate in Community College Leadership Program at East Tennessee State University.

Dell, M.* (2023, November 29). *The Tennessee Coaching Project*. Guest lecture delivered in Dr. Eric Bettinger's Experimental Research Design and Analysis (EDUC 430A) class at Stanford University.

Lehnert, P., **Dell, M.**, Backes-Gellner, U., & Bettinger, E.* (2023, November 1). *The effect of postsecondary institutions on local economies: A bird's-eye view*. Paper presented at the [Hoover Institution's Economic Policy Working Group at Stanford University](#).

Dell, M.*, Monday, A., & Gentile, S. (2022, June 29). *Estimating the impact of PLUS loan policy changes on historically Black colleges and universities*. Paper presented at the University of Zurich's PhD Discussion Workshop: Personnel Economics and Economics of Education in Laax, Switzerland.

Backes-Gellner, U., Bettinger, E.*, **Dell, M.**, & Lehnert, P. (2022, February 17). *The effect of postsecondary institutions on local economies: A bird's-eye view*. Paper presented at the Swiss Leading House's "[Friday Lunch Talk Series](#)" at the University of Zurich.

Conference Presentations

Details about each presentation are available upon request; * indicates presentations I delivered

2026: COPE;* LEER;* ifo Dresden Workshop; IAB HELM;* SASE;* AOM (poster);* AQMAPPS*

2025: AOM;* VET Workshop (Bergamo, Italy)*

2024: APPAM; SREE; TENNAIR;* AEF; DREAM;* TBR Advising Academy*

2023: NACADA;* TBR Advising Academy*
2022: First International Leading House Conference;* APPAM;* AEFP;* COPE
2021: AEFP*
2020: APPAM*
2019: ASHE; APPAM (poster);* TENNAIR;* EPSOs in Action (Nashville, Tennessee)*
2018: ASHE*
2017: ASHE (poster);* College Promise Programs workshop (Philadelphia, Pennsylvania)
2016: SACSCOC;* NSSR*

Service

Journal Referee: *Review of Educational Research*, *Journal of Student Financial Aid*
Associate Editor: AOM (2026, Public and Nonprofit Division)
Proposal Reviewer: SREE (2026); AOM (2026, Human Resources Division); DRUID (2023, 2025–2026); AERA (2020–2021); NCES Data Institute (2018–2020); ASHE (2018–2019)
Panelist: ASHE Graduate Student Policy Seminar (2023–2024)
Conference Roles: COPE (session chair, 2025); Stanford GSE Student Conference (committee member, 2020); ASHE (session chair, 2018); We All Rise Conference (committee co-chair, 2018)

Relevant Employment

Consultant, Evaluation and Assessment Solutions for Education	2025–
Research Assistant, Funder: Student Loan Law Initiative (PI: Daniel Collier)	2020–
Graduate Research Assistant, John W. Gardner Center , Stanford University	2020–22
Contract Researcher, Funder: Arnold Ventures (PI: SHEEO)	2020–21

Technical Skills

Stata, R (quantitative analysis); LaTeX; SQL (administrative data management); Power BI, Tableau (data visualization); QuestionPro (survey platforms); Dedoose (qualitative analysis)